

First Dabba Discourse

Paṭhamadabbasutta (Ud 8.9)

Evam me sutam— ekam samayaṃ bhagavā rājagahe viharati veḷuvane
kalandakanivāpe. Atha kho āyasmā dabbo mallaputto yena bhagavā
tenupasaṅkami; upasaṅkamitvā bhagavantam abhivādetvā ekamantaṃ nisīdi.
Ekamantaṃ nisinno kho āyasmā dabbo mallaputto bhagavantam etadavoca:
“parinibbānakālo me dāni, sugatā”ti. “Yassadāni tvaṃ, dabba, kālaṃ maññasī”ti.

Thus have I heard— At one time the Blessed One was staying at Rājagaha in the Bamboo Grove, the Squirrels' Feeding Ground. Then the Venerable Dabba Mallaputta went to the Blessed One, paid respects, and sat down to one side. Sitting there to one side, the Venerable Dabba Mallaputta said to the Blessed One: “Now is the time for my final passing away (*parinibbāna*), O Happy One (*sugata*).” “Dabba, do what you think is best now.”

Atha kho āyasmā dabbo mallaputto utṭhāyāsanaṃ bhagavantam abhivādetvā
padakkhiṇaṃ katvā vehāsaṃ abbhuggantvā ākāse antalikkhe pallaṅkena nisīditvā
tejodhātuṃ samāpajjitvā vuṭṭhahitvā parinibbāyi.

Then the Venerable Dabba Mallaputta rose from his seat, paid respects to the Blessed One, circled him keeping him on his right, and rose up into the air. Sitting cross-legged in the sky, he entered the fire element (*tejodhātu*), emerged from it, and attained *parinibbāna*.

Atha kho āyasmato dabbassa mallaputtassa vehāsaṃ abbhuggantvā ākāse
antalikkhe pallaṅkena nisīditvā tejodhātuṃ samāpajjitvā vuṭṭhahitvā parinibbutassa
sarīrassa jhāyamānassa ḍayhamānassa neva chārikā paññāyittha na masi.
Seyyathāpi nāma sappissa vā telassa vā jhāyamānassa ḍayhamānassa neva
chārikā paññāyati na masi; evamevaṃ āyasmato dabbassa mallaputtassa vehāsaṃ
abbhuggantvā ākāse antalikkhe pallaṅkena nisīditvā tejodhātuṃ samāpajjitvā
vuṭṭhahitvā parinibbutassa sarīrassa jhāyamānassa ḍayhamānassa neva chārikā
paññāyittha na masīti.

And when the body of the Venerable Dabba Mallaputta—who had risen into the air, sat cross-legged in the sky, entered the fire element, emerged from it, and attained *parinibbāna*—was burned and consumed, neither ashes nor soot remained. Just as when ghee or oil is burned and consumed, neither ashes nor soot remain; in the very same way, when the body of the Venerable Dabba Mallaputta—who had risen into the air, sat cross-legged in the sky, entered the fire element, emerged from it, and attained *parinibbāna*—was burned and consumed, neither ashes nor soot remained.

Atha kho bhagavā etamatthaṃ viditvā tāyaṃ velāyaṃ imaṃ udānaṃ udānesi:

Then the Blessed One, understanding this, uttered this inspired utterance on that occasion:

“Abhedi kāyo nirodhi saññā, Vedanā sītibhaviṃsu sabbā; Vūpasamiṃsu saṅkhārā,
Viññāṇaṃ atthamāgamā”ti.

“The body broke up, perception (*saññā*) ceased, All sensations (*vedanās*) cooled down; All mental conditioning (*saṅkhāras*) subsided, Consciousness (*viññāṇa*) came to an end.”

Navamaṃ.

(Ninth)

Glossary

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
parinibbāna	parinibbāna	final passing away	First Dabba Discourse	The complete passing away/liberation of an enlightened being, leaving no residue of conditioned existence.
sugata	sugata	Happy One	First Dabba Discourse	An epithet of the Buddha, referring to one who has gone to a good state, a well-gone one.
tejodhātu	tejodhātu	fire element	First Dabba Discourse	The element of heat/fire, one of the four primary elements (<i>mahābhūtā</i>)

Pāli (IAST)	Target transliteration	Target gloss	First-chapter occurrence	Goenka-tradition usage
				representing temperature and transformation.
saññā	saññā	perception	First Dabba Discourse	The aggregate of recognition, label, and evaluation of sensory input.
vedanā	vedanā	sensations	First Dabba Discourse	The aggregate of feeling or experiencing bodily sensations.
saṅkhāra	saṅkhāra	mental conditioning	First Dabba Discourse	The aggregate of mental reactions and volitional formations.
viññāṇa	viññāṇa	consciousness	First Dabba Discourse	The aggregate of bare cognition or awareness of an object.

Translator Notes

1. **Intimate Teacher-to-Student Voice:** The English translation maintains a direct and experiential tone, matching Goenkaji's spoken style.
2. **Burned and Consumed (*jhāyamānassa* *ḍayhamānassa*):** Translated as "burned and consumed" for both the body of Dabba Mallaputta and the ghee/oil in the simile, maintaining parallelism and avoiding technical words like "cremated" that do not apply to liquid fats.
3. **Fire Element (*tejodhātu*):** Retained in Pāli with an English gloss to emphasize the meditative attainment of fire-element concentration (*tejodhātu-samāpatti*) which led to the residue-free passing away.

4. **The Aggregates in Verse:** Restructured the verse to clearly isolate the four mental aggregates (*saññā*, *vedanā*, *saṅkhāra*, *viññāṇa*) and their cessation, mirroring the meditative path of observing the arising and passing of sensations.